47

To get the spending and tax cuts we wanted through Congress, we needed the help of a substantial number of Democrats in the House as well as the votes of virtually all the Republicans in both houses of Congress. I spent a lot of time in the spring and early summer of 1981 on the telephone and in meetings trying to build a coalition to get the nation's recovery under way. Reeling from the effects of years of mismanagement, the economy was falling deeper into recession every day. I knew things wouldn't get better until we got the recovery program up and running. I met dozens of times with congressmen from both parties, on Capitol Hill and at the White House, trying to explain what it was we were trying to accomplish and to rebut erroneous reports in the press and fictions about the program being spread by Tip O'Neill.

Sometimes I made a convert, sometimes not. I remember one example of the efficiency of the White House operators: We were approaching an important vote on our proposed budget cuts when I asked to speak to a certain congressman. After quite a delay, I got a call back from him and I said jovially, "Where did we find you?" He said, "New Zealand." I said, "What time is it in New Zealand?" He answered, *"Four o'clock in the morning."* I wanted to hang up and pretend I'd never called him; but instead, after an apology, I proceeded with my pitch. When he got back to Washington, he voted with us.

Opinion polls showed ninety-five percent of the American people were behind the proposed spending cuts and almost as many supported the thirty-percent, three-year tax cut. But Tip O'Neill and other Democratic leaders in Congress